



THE ANVIL



MACG

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CHINESE WORKERS FIGHT BACK



Credit: Wall Street Journal

What is the significance of the recent protests in China and what should we take from them here in Australia?

The capitalist press have mostly stuck to a simplistic explanation based purely on opposition to Covid lockdowns. Clearly, the draconian policing of a 'Zero Covid' policy which had become unrealistic (implemented as a substitute for a poorly executed vaccination effort and significantly privatised health system) has been a major source of anger. An important event in building popular support for the protests was a deadly fire in a Xinjiang apartment building, which resulted in at least ten people dying. Many locals blamed the inadequate response time by firefighters on Covid restrictions. But there is much more to these protests than just anger over Covid restrictions. Furthermore, we can easily debunk conspiratorial narratives that this is some

kind of right-wing or Western controlled movement. Instead, it is a manifestation of class war, which many Chinese workers continue to frame in socialist terms.

The Foxconn Strike

Particularly neglected in Western coverage of China is the component of labour struggle. A major development in the build up to the protests was the militant confrontation between workers and police at the Foxconn mega-factory in the city of Zhengzhou.

Foxconn is a Taiwanese company best known for producing iPhones for Apple, as well as working conditions so brutal that 'suicide nets' have been built outside of factory windows, to prevent workers leaping to their deaths. To comply with government Covid restrictions, Foxconn had forced workers to live in the factory from October through to November in appalling conditions. Eventually, many workers escaped and quit, forcing the State to work with the company to offer pay raises and bonuses to attract new workers. When the workers arrived they found that the promises of higher pay didn't materialise. On top of this, they became furious about the handling of Covid – in this case because workers who tested positive

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STATE OF THE UNION MOVEMENT

We are witnessing the slow extinction of Australia's trade union movement. In 1976, 2.5 million Australian workers (some 51.6% of the workforce) were members of a trade union. As of August this year, trade union density in Australia has fallen to 12.5% (1.4 million people). The Australian trade union movement is older than ever before, only 2% of employed 15-19 year olds and 5% of 20-24 year olds are members of a union (ABS 2022).

The decline in union membership is mirrored by a decline in industrial action. In the December quarter of 1991, 589,000 Australian workers spent at least a day on strike. The latest quarterly figures for this year record 28,000 workers involved in industrial action. As bad as this seems, it still represents a relative uptick since the COVID lockdowns.

Trade unions are built in struggle. Unions are built and grow when workers strike and win. In Australia, successive Labor and Liberal governments have built one of the most restrictive legal frameworks for industrial action in the developed world. It is exceptionally difficult to go on strike in Australia, and without the support of the union bureaucracy, almost impossible.

The union bureaucracy has strong incentives to avoid strikes, and especially to avoid the kinds that would be necessary to break out of the legal straightjacket of the Fair Work Act. Australia's legal framework, and the loyalty of the union officials to the ALP, create a relatively privileged position for the formal union leadership. For unions that step out of line, there are substantial fines, and the threat of deregistration. The threat of



Credit: AAP/Richard Wainwright

deregistration is significant, since unions depend on the few legal privileges that registration brings in order to maintain what membership they have.

The trade union bureaucracy has shown that it cannot break from its legal and political straight jacket (one partly of its own making). There are relative strongholds in education and healthcare (where the fear of legal liability compels workers to join their union) but the unions, as currently organised, are doomed. The officials cannot defend the institution over which they preside.

However, the death of the union movement would not be a good thing. Despite the inadequacies of formal Australian trade unions, the 1.5 million members of Australian unions are still the most organised segment of the Australian working class. The loss of union organisation will only lead to further losses in wages, conditions, and the relative strength of the class.

The union movement must be rebuilt and as soon as possible. It will only be harder the more the movement declines. Rebuilding can only be done through a rank and file insurgency. There may be times and places where it is appropriate to organise new unions (for example in entirely unorganised parts of the workforce,

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Chinese workers fight back

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for Covid were not being separated from others. In other words, when Foxconn workers once again stormed out of the factory and confronted police, they did so on the basis of pay and workplace safety.

From Social Media to the Street

News of the strike spread across Chinese social media and messenger apps. Watsonweibo, which monitors these platforms, reported that

“a clear majority of the people speak out in support of the Foxconn workers. They post old propaganda posters that emphasize how the Chinese working class will lead the revolution, and recommend other Weibo users to read Karl Marx. ‘Is the working class still leading?’, they ask.”

Despite what many people think, protest is not rare in China. There is intense working class militancy, frequent struggles in rural areas over land and social services, and also student protest. What is rare is dissent against the political system as a whole, the rapid spread of protest across the country, and the intermingling of different struggles. In the case of the recent protests, we saw both uncommon examples of political dissent and its rapid spread across various regions. There was widespread mourning of those who died in the Xinjiang fire, with some making open reference to the repression of the Uyghurs. Workers took to the streets singing the Internationale. Slogans calling for the fall of Xi Jinping and the Chinese “Communist” Party dictatorship could be heard in multiple cities. University students began calling for freedom of speech and democracy. Others held up sheets of blank A4 paper – a defiant

symbol conveying the same message. In one video, a person opposed to the protests echoes the narrative that the West is behind the unrest. The man asks the crowd if they know that “foreign forces” are manipulating them. Someone with a megaphone responds: “The foreign forces you are talking about, are they Marx and Engels?” In another video, a student comes amazingly close to a famous phrase from Bakunin: “No socialism without freedom! No freedom without socialism!” Certain Covid restrictions have now been eased, particularly in cities where the rebellion was strongest. Protest has waned, but now the Party’s incompetent management of the pandemic threatens to overwhelm the healthcare system, which could easily lead people back to striking and hitting the streets.

No War Between Nations, No Peace Between Classes

In Australia, the major political parties are increasingly militaristic in their attitudes towards China, and the capitalist media repeatedly warns us about the supposed ‘Chinese threat’. Incredibly, even when the people of China rise up against their own ruling class, the framing of the coverage barely changes at all. When Chinese workers show that they also oppose their government, it is seen as just another opportunity to encourage Australians to embrace militarisation and a readiness for the possibility of war.

The working class of Australia has no interest in a war against Chinese workers and Chinese workers have no interest in a war with us. Militarisation and war is a ruling class game. We have far more in common with each other than either of us

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do with the ruling classes of our countries. And just as so many Chinese workers (under much harsher conditions than our own) have had the bravery to fight the bosses and politicians who exploit and oppress them, rather than embrace a nationalist fight against ‘foreign forces’, we should also recognise that our main enemy is here at home. They manage our workplaces and make our laws. The only war worth fighting is the class war against them.

WORKERS OF THE WORLD UNITE!

NO WAR BUT CLASS WAR!

Union Decline...

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or where the existing union is wholly on the side of the bosses and cannot be recaptured by its members). Most workers, though, will not break with the officials until they are already mobilised and a practical decision is in front of them, so the insurgency must operate largely within existing unions.

Though the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group advocates a rank and file movement within the existing unions, it mustn’t be bound to the current legal structures. It needs to operate independently of the union bureaucracy in order to build the strength that is needed to break with the legal and political limits of Australia’s industrial relations system. And it is only by breaching those limits that the union movement can survive.

MACG

What is Anarchism?

Anarchism is a social philosophy based upon the principles of liberty, equality and solidarity. It is the political dimension of a free society.

What is Communism?

Communism is the principle of “from each according to their ability, to each according to their need”. It is the economic dimension of a free society.

What is the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group?

The MACG is an organisation of class struggle revolutionary anarchists who share political positions, articulated in theory, strategy and tactics.

We aim to encourage struggle by the working class for its own interests and, within that struggle, we aim to advance Anarchist ideas as its necessary philosophical basis.

IF YOU DON’T FIGHT YOU LOSE

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